

ARTS

Creativity at a New Address

It's time for art lovers in south India to rejoice. The Jose Thomas Performance Art Centre (JTPAC) is now being referred to as a new home for the arts in south India. The centre opened with a bang in Kochi with the state's who's who present. JTPAC is possibly Kerala's only state-of-the-art auditorium with lights, sounds and seating for more than 600 people. Owned and run by the Choice Group's Jose Thomas, JTPAC's Chairman is actor Mohanlal. The spectacular inauguration included dance, music and rhythm and saw a performance conceived by Soorya Krishnamoorthy with more than 70 performers on stage. Masters and gurus like Kathakali artist Kalamandalam Gopi, Chenda artist Mattannur Sankarankutty Marar, Mohiniyattam exponent Kalamandalam Leelamma, Mizhavu artist Narayanan Nambiar, theatre stalwart Kavalam Narayana Panicker, Sopanam singer Janardhana Nedungady and Marathukali artist

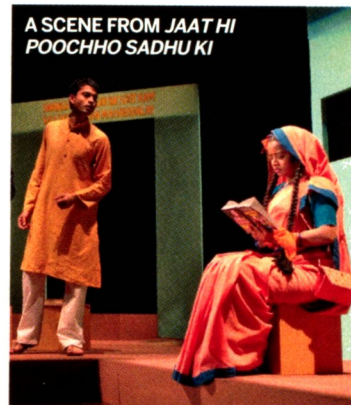
Pokkan Manicker were felicitated by JTPAC and a fellowship and cash awards were introduced for senior artists annually. JTPAC will showcase performances from across the country and abroad on a regular basis with special emphasis on dance, music and theatre. "I hope Kochi can become a new destination for the arts with JTPAC," says Thomas. Exchange programmes with other auditoriums across India are being planned, besides a mega theatre production of Shakespeare's *Tempest* with Mohanlal leading it. The year-long schedule begins with two music shows in April. L. Subramaniam, Kavita Krishnamurti Subramaniam, Ambi Subramaniam, Bindu Subramaniam, Louis Banks and Gino Banks will regale Kochi audiences with contemporary fusion music on April 4, while Usha Uthup and The Sound will perform Contemporary Jazz Music on April 26. At JTPAC, Kochi.

by Nirmala Ravindran

SAMUDRA PERFORMING AT THE INAUGURATION OF THE JTPAC



A SCENE FROM JAAT HI POOCHHO SADHU KI



DRAMA FESTIVAL

Playing THE PAST

Vijay Tendulkar is known for his skilful depiction of the anger that festers inside his deep-rooted characters. The master that he is, Tendulkar maintains a satirical approach even while tackling serious issues. *Jaat Hi Poochho Sadhu Ki* is actually a strong comment on caste politics and the inefficiency in education, set in a college being run in an animal yard. Its characters mock their own weaknesses in the act of appreciating them. In an interview for a professor's post, the protagonist is asked to recite some lines from the nautanki of *Chhappan Chhuri* and he starts singing *Aalha*, a ballad about two warriors. He is selected; one has to laugh at the foolishness of the inter-viewers. This play is now being staged at the National School of Drama (NSD) Repertory, which is devoid of talented actors today. The only saving grace is the direction of Rajinder Nath, who has mastered Tendulkar's plays. In 1978, Nath first staged this play with his group Abhiyan, with actor S.M. Zaheer in the lead role. From April 2 to 5 in Delhi.

by Sheekesh Mishra